

Bureaucracy and Law: The Silent War

In *Zero Sum*, the most dangerous adversaries do not carry firearms. They carry clipboards, injunctions, and itemized billing software. Combat against the system is fought through litigation, metadata scraping, and leveraging secrets.

1. The Auditors

The Auditors are corporate accountants flanked by heavily armed, private military contractors. They represent the apex predators of the financial ecosystem. - **Modus Operandi:** Auditors do not shoot; they arrive mid-firefight or shortly after to serve immediate legal injunctions. - **Abilities:** They can remotely freeze a character's bank accounts, revoke DRM licenses on cybernetics or weaponry, and legally claim a character's internal organs to settle defaulted debts. - **Engagement:** Engaging an Auditor with violence is financial suicide. Every bullet fired at an Auditor incurs a 1,000% "Aggravated Assault Surcharge" billed directly to your next-of-kin.

2. OSINT and Blackmail (Social Combat)

There is no "Charisma" stat. You cannot smile your way out of a corporate execution. Social encounters are resolved using **Leverage**. - **Mechanic:** Players must use Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT), metadata scraping, and doxxing to find a target's pressure points before negotiations begin. - **The Cost of Winning:** Winning a negotiation means you successfully leveraged a threat (e.g., exposing a Syndicate boss's offshore accounts). However, to do so, you inevitably leave a digital footprint or expose your own vulnerabilities. Every social victory creates a future noose. - **Example:** You secure a cache of medical supplies from a broker by threatening their family, but the transaction log permanently records your biometric signature, making you traceable.

3. Collateral Damage Billing

Combat is not just physically destructive; it is a financial disaster.

- **Ubiquitous Sensors:** Corporate zones are saturated with micro-sensors that log every missed shot, broken window, and drop of spilled blood.
- **The Itemized Bill:** When resolving combat, players are hit with a literal itemized bill.
- *Unauthorized Bio-Hazard Cleanup (Per liter of blood spilled): \$400*
- *Municipal Property Damage (Per bullet hole in corporate drywall): \$1,200*
- *Disruption of Commerce Surcharge: \$5,000*
- **Resolution:** If the bill exceeds the payout of the gig, the players end the session deeper in debt than they started.